

CARDO

THE DISCIPLINE BLUEPRINT

How I lost 150 pounds — and the exact system you can use to do it too.

by Cardo

Read this first. I'm not a doctor, a registered dietitian, or a certified personal trainer. I'm a guy who lost 150 pounds and kept it off by being consistent for a long time. Everything here is what I did and what I learned doing it. Before you change how you eat or start training, talk to your doctor — especially if you have any medical conditions, take medication, are pregnant, or have any history of an eating disorder. Use this as a map, not a prescription. Your body is yours to figure out. This guide helps you figure it out.

There Is No Secret

I didn't lose 150 pounds because I found a secret. There is no secret. I lost it because I did a small number of boring things over and over for a very long time, and I didn't quit when it got hard or slow.

That's the whole thing. If you're looking for a hack, a tea, a 21-day shred — close this and get your money back. I don't do that, because it doesn't work and it made me feel like garbage every time I tried it.

What I *do* have is a system. It's repeatable, it's sustainable, and it's built for a real person with a job and a life — because that's exactly what I was the whole time I was losing the weight. This guide is that system, plus the mindset that made me actually stick to it.

The Only Four That Matter

Everything else is detail. If you only did these four, you'd still lose weight.

1. You have to be in a calorie deficit.

Eat less energy than you burn, over time, and you lose fat. Every diet that works — keto, carb cycling, fasting — works *because* it creates a deficit, not because it's magic.

2. Protein is your priority.

In a deficit, protein protects your muscle and keeps you full. It's the single most important thing on your plate. I built every meal around it.

3. You have to sustain it for months.

The plan you can follow for six months beats the perfect plan you quit in nine days. I chose sustainable over intense every time — and that's why it worked.

4. Consistency beats perfection.

I was never perfect. Bad days, treat meals, missed workouts. I lost 150 lbs anyway, because I never let one bad day become a bad week. You won't be perfect either. Just don't quit.

Do Not Skip This

I'm not handing you my calorie target, because my numbers are built for my body and my training. If I gave them to you, they'd be wrong for you. Instead I'll teach you to find your own — the same way I found mine.

Step 1 — Estimate maintenance

Search "TDEE calculator," plug in your age, height, weight and activity. That number is what keeps your weight where it is. Write it down — that's your baseline.

Step 2 — Set your deficit

To lose fat, eat below maintenance. A sustainable starting deficit for most people is about 300–500 calories below maintenance. Smaller = slower but easier. Bigger = faster but harder to hold. I went sustainable every time.

Step 3 — Track and adjust

Weigh in daily, first thing, and take the WEEKLY AVERAGE — never a single day. If the average drops ~0.5–1% of bodyweight per week, keep going. If it stalls 2–3 weeks, eat a little less or move a little more. If it's crashing and you feel awful, eat a bit more. You're running an experiment on yourself. The scale is your data.

Step 4 — Set your protein

Aim for roughly 0.7–1 gram of protein per pound of your GOAL bodyweight per day. Hit this first, every day, before anything else on the plate.

Steal What Works For You

Protein first, always

I decided the protein, then built the plate around it. Chicken, lean beef, eggs, fish, Greek yogurt, protein powder. Lock protein in and the rest gets easy.

Mostly whole foods

Not because processed food is evil — because whole foods are more filling per calorie. In a deficit, being full is everything. Lean meats, eggs, potatoes, rice, oats, fruit, veg, legumes.

Track honestly

Log your food, especially at the start. Most people badly underestimate what they eat. Weigh your food for the first few weeks — you'll be shocked what a real serving is.

Plan a treat on purpose

I built a treat meal into every week — planned, not guilty. Total deprivation is how you end up bingeing at 11pm. A planned treat is a pressure valve. Use it.

My favorite satiety hacks

- Rice cakes + powdered peanut butter + sugar-free chocolate syrup — tastes like dessert, tiny calories, keeps evening energy up.
- High-volume foods — vegetables, broth soups, fruit. They fill your stomach for almost nothing.
- Drink water before meals. Half of "hunger" is often thirst.

Build The Body, Not Just Shrink It

You can lose weight without exercise — it's a kitchen game first. But training changed my *body*, not just my weight. It built muscle, protected my strength while I cut, and made me feel strong instead of just smaller.

Find your untouchable time

I trained at 5am six days a week — not because 5am is magic, but because nothing could take it from me. Find the time your life can't steal. The best schedule is the one that survives your actual week.

Push / Pull / Legs

I cycled Push (chest, shoulders, triceps), Pull (back, biceps), Legs (quads, hams, glutes, calves). If six days is too much right now, DO NOT copy me — start with 3 full-body days. Three you actually do beats six you burn out on.

Get stronger over time

Progressive overload — adding a little weight or a rep over time — is what builds muscle. Chase slow steady progress on your lifts, not soreness. Log your workouts.

Let steps do the cardio

I didn't kill myself on the treadmill. Daily walking burns real calories without wrecking recovery or spiking appetite. Walk more. It's free and underrated.

The Part Nobody Teaches

This is what separates people who keep it off from people who yo-yo. You cannot cut forever. After months of hard training and eating in a deficit, fatigue builds — energy, sleep, mood, motivation all take a hit.

When I feel it building, I take a PLANNED break: a few days eating at maintenance and resting, on purpose, before getting back to it. That's not falling off — it's programmed recovery. Build rest into the plan. Take a full rest day weekly. Sleep 7–9 hours; that's where your body actually changes.

If you're exhausted, not sleeping, and hating your life, you're not being disciplined — you're overreaching. Back off, recover, come back stronger. That's the pro move.

Learn These The Easy Way

- **Going too aggressive too fast.** Feels productive for a week, then you crash and binge. Slow wins.
- **Not tracking, then wondering why nothing moves.** If the scale's stuck, you're almost always eating more than you think.
- **Chasing the daily scale number.** It bounces from water and salt. Watch the weekly average or you'll go insane.
- **All-or-nothing thinking.** One bad meal isn't failure. Quitting over it is. Get right back on the next meal.
- **Comparing your chapter 1 to someone's chapter 20.** It took me a long time. Your job is to not quit, not to be fast.

Start Tonight

Don't overhaul your life on day one. Do this:

Day 1	Calculate your maintenance calories and set your deficit. Write your numbers down.
Day 2	Download a food tracking app. Log everything today — don't change anything yet, just see the truth.
Day 3	Figure out your protein target and hit it. Build meals around protein.
Day 4	Pick your untouchable training time. Do one workout — full body, nothing crazy.
Day 5	Get your steps up. Go for a walk. Log your food again.
Day 6	Plan your treat meal for the week. Yes, on purpose.
Day 7	Rest. Weigh in each morning this week and start tracking your average.

Then repeat. That's the whole thing. Boring, repeatable, and it works — I'm proof.

LAST WORD

You Can Do This

I was 150 pounds heavier. I had every excuse available and I used most of them for years. What changed wasn't my willpower — it was my SYSTEM. I stopped trying to be perfect and started being consistent. I made the plan fit my life instead of forcing my life around a plan I couldn't sustain.

You can do this. Not in a month. But you absolutely can. Start with day one and don't quit.

— **Cardo**

This guide reflects my personal experience and general information only. It is not medical, nutritional, or fitness advice, and is not a substitute for consultation with a qualified professional. Consult your physician before beginning any diet or exercise program. Results vary from person to person.

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